

3.2.3 2C Hinduism

Students are required to study those aspects of the religious beliefs, teachings, values and practices of Hinduism specified below and the different ways in which these are expressed in the lives of individuals, communities and societies.

They should develop a knowledge and critical understanding of:

- the specified material
- how the texts specified for study are interpreted and applied
- the influence of beliefs and teachings on individuals, communities and societies
- the causes, meanings and significance of similarities and differences in religious thought belief and practice within Hinduism
- approaches to the study of religion and belief.

They should be able to analyse and evaluate issues arising from the topics studied, and the views and arguments of the scholars prescribed for study.

Questions may be set that span more than one topic.

Students may study any version of the specified texts, but should be aware of issues related to translation where relevant. Quotations will not be used in questions.

Students should be able to use specialist language and terminology appropriately.

Exam questions will show a translation for any non-English terms (except for names of people, texts and schools of thought). However students are expected to recognise and understand the following technical terms: Trimurti, avatar, karma, ahimsa, darshan.

Section A: Hinduism

Sources of wisdom and authority

- The Vedas: concept of shruti (that which is heard); the nature and authority of the Vedas, their use in worship and their importance; the distinctive nature of the Upanishads and their importance for Hindu thought; the significance of the teaching in the Purusha Sukta of the Rig Veda about the origin of the caste system.
- The smṛti texts: the status of the smṛti (remembered) texts; the importance of the following: the Ramayana; the Bhagavad Gita and the Manusmṛti.
- Gurus: the role and authority of gurus in the modern world with reference to Swami Sivananda.

Ultimate reality

- Differing ideas about God and gods in the Rig Veda, and their importance for Hinduism today.
- The Trimurti: the nature and roles of the three elements of the Trimurti and their relationship with Brahman; the concept of avatar with particular reference to Krishna and Rama; the importance of the Trimurti and avatars in Hinduism.
- Nirguna and Saguna Brahman: Nirguna Brahman as nothingness, without qualities, beyond description and understanding; Saguna Brahman with qualities and as a personal God; the importance of both concepts for Hindus, Kena Upanishad 1:3–8.

Self, death and afterlife

- The meaning and purpose of life: the four aims of life; and their relative importance; different understandings of the nature of moksha.
- Atman: the concept of atman and its relationship with the body and with Brahman, with reference to the views of Advaita Vedanta (non-dualism) and Samkhya (dualism) the parable of the chariot: Katha Upanishad 3.
- Samsara: the concept of samsara; beliefs about reincarnation and the causes of reincarnation with reference to the different types of karma; the realms of reincarnation and the interconnectedness of all life.

Good conduct and key moral principles

- Good conduct: the importance of good moral conduct in Hinduism with reference to karma and karma yoga (selfless effort).
- Dharma: the concepts of Sanatana dharma (universal dharma), Varnashrama dharma (dharma for class and stage of life) and the relationship between them; the importance of each for the Hindu way of life.
- Ahimsa: the virtue of ahimsa, its application to issues concerning the embryo and the unborn child, treatment of animals and war including the use of weapons of mass destruction; different Hindu views on these issues including Gandhi's views on non-violence.

Expressions of religious identity

- Yoga: the different paths of Yoga, their suitability for different types of character and the links between them.
- Bhakti Yoga: the nature and importance of bhakti yoga; darshan at shrines, temples and on pilgrimage with particular reference to the Ganges; the key aspects of puja.
- The changing role of ashrams: ashrams (spiritual retreat centres) in Hinduism; their role prior to the 20th century and the variety of types of ashram today, with particular reference to the Sivananda Yoga Vedanta Dhanwantari Ashram in Kerala, and Skanda Vale Ashram UK.

Hinduism, gender and sexuality

Historical and social factors that have influenced developments in Hindu thinking about these issues with particular reference to India, including: encounter with western values and lifestyles as part of the British Empire; the changing roles of men and women in society outside of religion, the rights given to women by secular governments.

Developments in Hindu thought including feminist approaches:

- Debates about the role and status of women in Hinduism with particular reference to the contribution of Ram Mohan Roy.
- The work of the Manushi organisation in modern India.
- Different Hindu views about celibacy, marriage and divorce, homosexuality and transgender issues.

Hinduism and science

How and why science has influenced Hinduism and how Hinduism has responded, with particular reference to: science's emphasis on evidence and reason; specific scientific discoveries; science as a stimulus to Hindu ethical thinking.

Developments in Hindu thought:

- How science has challenged Hinduism and Hindu responses to Darwin's theory of evolution and the Big Bang theory, including the views of ISKCON.
- The belief that science is compatible with Hinduism with reference to the views of Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan about the scientific basis of Hinduism, and the belief that scientific discoveries were revealed in the Vedas.
- Different Hindu responses to ethical issues raised by science: genetic engineering.

Hinduism and the challenge of secularisation

In India: the 19th century context and the encounter with western values; comparison of the significant ideas of Ram Mohan Roy and Dayananda Saraswati about the nature of Hinduism.

Practical Vedanta: the reinterpretation of Advaita Vedanta in the work of Vivekananda and its present expression in the work of the Ramakrishna Mission, a liberationist Hindu approach, supporting the poor and defending the oppressed.

In Britain: the challenge of secularisation including the replacement of religion as the source of truth and moral values; relegation of religion to the personal sphere; how Hinduism has responded to this challenge including: the preservation of existing sects such as Brahmo Samaj UK; the emergence of new forms of Hinduism including ISKCON.

Hinduism, migration and religious pluralism

How migration has created multicultural societies which include Hinduism, with particular reference to the development of Hinduism in Britain; diversity within the Hindu community in Britain; freedom of religion as a human right in European law and religious pluralism as a feature of modern secular states; the influence of this context on Hindu thought.

Developments in Hindu thought as a response to this context including:

- Vedanta as religion: the view that all faiths, and all traditions within Hinduism, are partial expressions of Vedanta and Hindu responses to that view.
- The importance of India for Hindus living elsewhere, and the possibility of sacred sites developing outside India.
- Hindu responses to issues of freedom of religious expression in society, including Hindutva.

The 21st century Indian secular context with particular reference to issues arising from freedom of religion, and the application of personal law to non-Hindu communities; different Hindu responses to this, including the response of the Sangh Parivar: its concept of Hindutva and definition of Hindu.

Section B: Dialogues

This section of the specification is focused on the connections between various elements of the course and requires students to develop breadth and depth in their understanding of the connections between the knowledge, understanding and skills set out in the specification. There are two areas for study, firstly the dialogue between Hinduism and philosophy: how developments in belief have, over time, influenced and been influenced by philosophical studies of religion, secondly the dialogue between Hinduism and ethics: how developments in belief have influenced and been influenced by ethical studies.

Students will be required to demonstrate a critical awareness of these connections and to analyse their nature.

The dialogue between Hinduism and philosophy

Beliefs and teachings about:

- ultimate reality
- self, death and afterlife
- sources of wisdom and authority
- religious experience
- the relationship between scientific and religious discourses
- the truth claims of other religions
- miracles.

The following issues, and the impact of the discussion on religious belief past and present, should be considered:

- How far the belief is reasonable – that is based on reason and/or consistent with reason
- How meaningful the statements of faith are, and for whom.
- How coherent the beliefs are, and how consistent with other beliefs within the belief system.
- The relevance of philosophical enquiry for religious faith, with particular reference to the debate about the nature of faith as ‘belief in’ or ‘belief that’.

Two unstructured questions will be set. Students must answer one.

The dialogue between Hinduism and ethics

- Hindu responses to the following approaches to moral decision-making in the light of key Hindu moral principles:
 - deontological, with reference to Kant.
 - teleological and consequential, with reference to Bentham.
 - character based, with reference to virtue ethics.
- How far Hindu ethics can be considered to be deontological, teleological, consequential, or character based.
- Hindu response to: the issues of human life and death and issues of animal life and death prescribed for study; theft and lying; marriage; homosexuality and transgender issues; genetic engineering.

- Hindu responses to issues surrounding wealth, tolerance and freedom of religious expression.
- Hindu understandings of free will and moral responsibility, and the value of conscience in Hindu moral decision-making.

The impact of other ethical perspectives and ethical studies on Hindu views about these issues, both past and present. This may include challenges to and support for Hindu views; compatibility of Hindu views with those of other ethical perspectives; the relative strengths and weaknesses of Hindu perspectives and the other ethical perspectives studied on these issues; the implications of criticisms of Hindu ethical teaching for the religion as a whole and its sources of authority.

Two unstructured questions will be set. Students must answer one.